

FEELING THE HEAT:
President Musharraf



The ground is slipping fast beneath his feet but those who know Musharraf well say he will cling on to power and will not step down unless pushed out.

the polls—if such a plan did at all exist—was found wanting in Pakistan's infamously meddlesome agencies.

What it all means for President Musharraf is that for all intents and purposes, he is now a lameduck president and a deeply unpopular one at that. Stripped of what he used to term his "second skin"—his army uniform—he has lost his greatest strength, his control over the army. With his political opponents in the ascendancy and who are likely to reassert Parliament's primary policy-

making position, his options are severely limited. But those who read him well say he will make every effort to hang on to power "like a barnacle". His best bet for survival—albeit only as a figure-head—would be a division between PPP and PML(N) to prevent them from forming a coalition against him.

From the looks of it, Musharraf is still counting on the fact that Zardari—who has something to fear from a much-too-politically-strong Sharif and a truly independent judiciary that might re-open some of the corruption

cases against him—would be willing to play ball with him. Zardari has stated publicly that the previous "understandings" with the Musharraf government brokered by his wife, stand nullified after her assassination, and that PPP would look "to bolster democracy rather than dictatorships". But sources indicate that presidential envoys, such as Musharraf's close confidant Tariq Aziz, have already had preliminary meetings with Zardari.

Whether Zardari falls into line with Musharraf at the expense of a popular backlash and perhaps even a split within his own party—some of the party's heavyweights, such as Supreme Court Bar Association President Aitzaz Ahsan, have taken a hard line against the President—still remains to be seen. In the unlikely event of Zardari turning his back on Sharif—who remains implacably opposed to Musharraf—he would also be going against popular opinion as shown in the elections.

But other than the skeletons in his closet, Zardari must also contend with the desperation of PPP's rank and file to taste power again. The party has been out of power now for almost 12 years and may see this as its best chance to keep its base satisfied. Theoretically, with the help of smaller parties such as the Muttahida Quami Movement (MQM) and the Awami National Party (ANP) and some independents, PPP could still cobble together a governing majority. This contrasts starkly with how Sharif views these elections—as mere stepping stones to the greater prize of future victories.

The restoration of some 60 sacked superior court judges—and particularly Chief Justice Iftikhar Chaudhry—is a troublesome legal issue. What would happen, for example, to the judges who had taken their place? Would it be judicially proper for the reinstated judges to then hear cases involving their tormentor, President Musharraf? Would reinstating them also mean reopening the cases already decided by the existing judges? One of the cases, taken up suo moto by the former Chief Justice and later dismissed by the current judges, was a challenge to the National Reconcilia-